1.1 The Pull of the West

If you had trouble finding work and heard about opportunities in a completely different part of the country, you just might pack up and move. That's exactly what settlers from the eastern half of the United States did in the 19th century. They packed up and moved west.

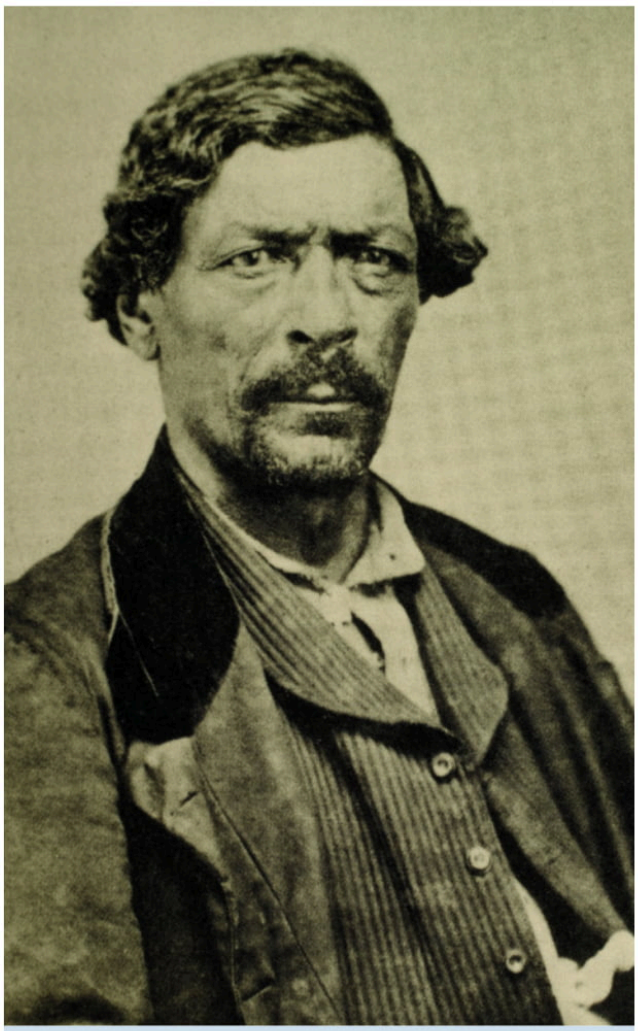
MAIN IDEA A tough economy and the promise of a rich and exciting future led Americans to look for opportunities in the West.

OPENING THE WEST

The boundaries of the nation shifted dramatically in the early 19th century, and the westward migration of easterners profoundly changed American culture. The West inspired ideals of **individualism**, or a self-reliant independence, and rugged frontier life that dramatically influenced our national self-image and sense of the American past.

In the early 19th century, Americans began to explore, move to, and live in the West. In 1806, Zebulon Pike led an expedition to discover the headwaters of the Arkansas River and was one of the first white men to explore the wilderness of Colorado. Many of these adventurous individuals were fur trappers and explorers, called **mountain men**. They spent most of their time in the wilderness trapping small animals for furs. Every summer from about 1825 to 1840, trappers met with fur traders at temporary markets called **rendezvous** (RAHN-deh-voo) to sell and buy goods and supplies. Trade opportunities like this were one of the economic incentives that drew people to the West.

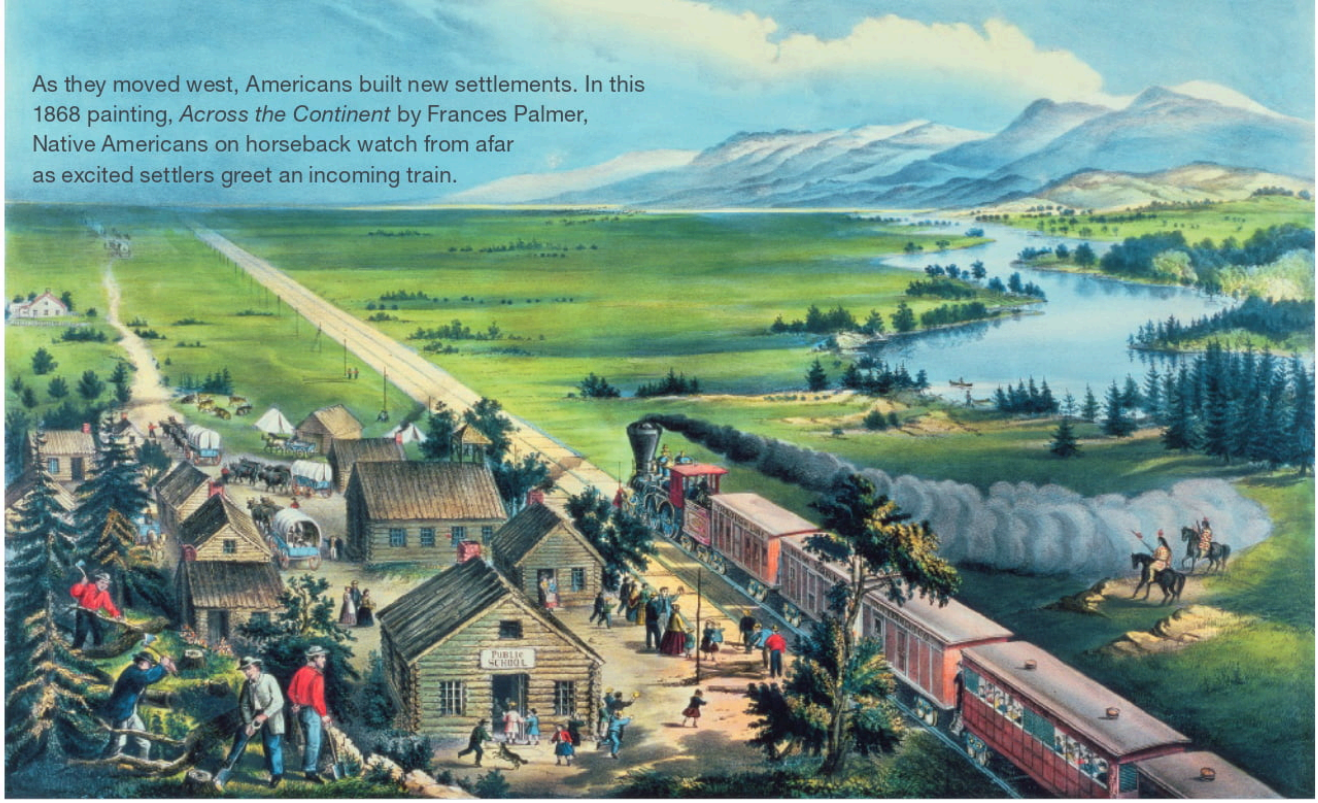
Several mountain men became legendary. Kit Carson, a successful fur trapper in California, would later use his skills to guide U.S. Army officers in a war with Mexico. Another legend was **Jedediah Smith**. Smith had read of Lewis and Clark's expeditions and decided to explore the West for himself. He would eventually explore more of the unknown territory of the West than any other single person. In 1826, Smith crossed the Mojave (moh-HAH-vee) Desert into southern California. The next year, he hiked through California's high



A Seasoned Mountain Man

Jim Beckwourth's adventures took him from the Everglades of Florida to northern Mexico, southern Canada, and the Pacific coast. While exploring the West, he lived with a Crow tribe for several years. He was also a prospector and a U.S. Army scout, and he learned to overcome many challenges of the frontier.

Copyright 2025 Cengage Learning. All Rights Reserved. May not be copied, scanned, or duplicated, in whole or in part. Due to electronic rights, some third party content may be suppressed from the eBook and/or eChapter(s). Editorial review has deemed that any suppressed content does not materially affect the overall learning experience. Cengage Learning reserves the right to remove additional content at any time if subsequent rights restrictions require it.



As they moved west, Americans built new settlements. In this 1868 painting, *Across the Continent* by Frances Palmer, Native Americans on horseback watch from afar as excited settlers greet an incoming train.

mountains, the Sierra Nevada, and became the first white American to travel overland from the East to California and back. Another mountain man who explored the Sierra Nevada was **Jim Beckwourth**. He had been born into slavery but was set free when he was 25. In 1850, he discovered a mountain pass through the Sierra Nevada for settlers to follow as they traveled to northern California. Today, that pass is still called Beckwourth Pass.

The mountain men's explorations opened lands that had previously seemed inaccessible. After the Panic of 1837, many Americans faced economic difficulties. Newly explored lands in the West started to look attractive to unhappy easterners, new immigrants, independent women, and others who were seeking a new start.

MANIFEST DESTINY

In 1845, magazine editor John O'Sullivan wrote an editorial urging the United States to **annex**, or add, Texas as a state. He also wrote that Americans had a "**manifest destiny** to overspread and possess the whole of the continent." The word *manifest* means "obvious," and *destiny* refers to the unavoidable events of the future. The phrase, and the purpose underlying manifest destiny, reflected several cultural assumptions, including the certainty that the United States would—indeed, should—one day stretch from the Atlantic Ocean to the Pacific Ocean. Those who embraced this concept were driven by more than just the promise of new opportunities. O'Sullivan's editorial described a belief that God intended for white Protestant Americans to take over the continent. Such an idea blatantly ignored the fact that there were already people living on these lands.

For several decades, the federal government pursued the territorial acquisition of western lands. The Oregon Territory promised timber, furs, and rich fisheries. California offered fertile farmland and abundant mineral resources, and both California and Oregon provided ports on the Pacific Ocean for seaboard merchants to ship and receive goods. Texas held deposits of minerals and metals, such as silver. The desire for riches and the belief in manifest destiny inspired settlers and politicians to move westward.

HISTORICAL THINKING

1. **READING CHECK** How did the concept of manifest destiny encourage Americans to move west?
2. **IDENTIFY MAIN IDEAS AND DETAILS** What natural resources served as economic incentives for people moving west?
3. **EVALUATE** Why might lands in the West have seemed inaccessible to many Americans?

Copyright 2025 Cengage Learning. All Rights Reserved. May not be copied, scanned, or duplicated, in whole or in part. Due to electronic rights, some third party content may be suppressed from the eBook and/or eChapter(s). Editorial review has deemed that any suppressed content does not materially affect the overall learning experience. Cengage Learning reserves the right to remove additional content at any time if subsequent rights restrictions require it.